🏷️ Plant Names & Life Cycles: Reading

Horticulture 1 · Unit 2 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Scientific Names, Flower Classification, Life Cycles

Name: _____

Naming and Grouping Plants

Plants have common names, like sunflower, and scientific names, like Helianthus annuus. Scientific names are written in Latin and have two parts: the genus and the species. Because the same scientific name is used in every country, scientists and growers always know exactly which plant is meant, even when common names differ from place to place.

There is a rule for writing scientific names. The genus is a noun that names the group, and it starts with a capital letter. The species is an adjective that describes which member of the group it is, and it is written in lowercase. The whole name is printed in italics or underlined when handwritten, for example Brassica rapa for mustard.

Flowers can be grouped by shape. A simple flower is a single flower with petals, like a tulip. A tube flower has petals joined into a tube, like a snapdragon or fuchsia. A composite flower, like a daisy or sunflower, looks like one flower but is really a head of many tiny florets.

Plants are also grouped by life cycle, which is how long it takes to grow, flower, make seed and die. Annuals finish in one growing season and are usually grown from seed. Biennials grow leaves the first year and flower the second. Perennials live three or more years and are often divided or grown from cuttings. About one in every 100 plant species is poisonous, so growers learn which plants are dangerous.

Check your reading

1. Write the mustard plant's scientific name correctly and explain the rule.

2. How is a composite flower different from a simple flower?

3. Compare annual and perennial life cycles.